

Theme and variations

Theme and variations is a musical form in which one melody provides continuity for the whole piece. The composer presents the theme repeatedly, but varies it each time in tempo, tonality, texture, dynamics, instrumentation, or overall style.

SEE ALSO

◀ 44–45 Tempo

◀ 104–105 Musical expression

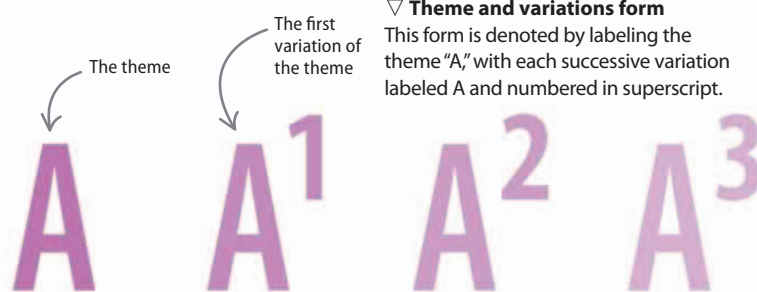
◀ 154–157 Repeats

Orchestral forms

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The same, but different

Theme and variations has been popular since the 17th century. One melody (typically 8 to 32 measures long) is creatively altered by the composer for a series of subsequent variations. Coherence is achieved because the theme is almost always recognizable in its new form.



▽ Theme and variations form

This form is denoted by labeling the theme “A,” with each successive variation labeled A and numbered in superscript.

Goldberg Variations

While Renaissance composers often wrote themes followed successively by more rhythmically difficult variations, Baroque composers solidified the form. J. S. Bach's most famous theme and variations, the 1741 *Goldberg Variations* for solo harpsichord (BWV 988), contains 30 versions of one simple aria. The piece is probably named after its first performer, Johann Goldberg.



△ Goldberg theme

This is a peaceful tune in G major. It is 32 measures long, and corresponds to the 32 sections of the entire piece (theme + 30 variations + theme).



△ Variation 1

The first variation contains lively running passages, but retains the same harmonic progression of the theme as well as the triple meter.



△ Variation 11

A virtuosic variation with close, even overlapping hand position, it is in the unusual time signature of 12/16 (doubling the more common 6/8).



△ Variation 30

This variation, the last in the piece, cleverly intersperses German folk song material with the theme in a jokey *quodlibet* (see p.162).